



“For the big films, pre-sale is happening, which is very difficult for the small films. There is no buyer for these films and you can’t blame the producer for not taking a punt on them”

SHIBASHISH SARKAR
CEO & CHAIRMAN, IMAC



“We experimented with ₹160-tickets across the country. Even at a lower price, people didn’t go. Ticket pricing is not a deterrent. It’s really about the content now”

SANJEEV KUMAR BIJLI
JOINT MANAGING
DIRECTOR, PVR



“If we feel it [a small movie] can become a blockbuster, we price it high. If we feel it is average, we price it accordingly. We are back to 85-90 per cent [occupancy] of 2019 levels”

ALOK TANDON
CEO, INOX LEISURE



“We encourage producers to take their film to the theatres first, and then to OTTs. It shows us the producer has confidence in the content. Also, it helps the overall marketing of films”

AJIT THAKUR
CEO, AHA

star power but by the story. That appreciation for a story is thanks to OTTs, where people started consuming more content.”

Experts see the reason for the smaller films not faring well at the theatres as being multi-pronged—a post-pandemic discerning audience that is now accustomed to international content; Hindi content that has not kept pace with the changing times; a four-week window for theatrical films to premiere on OTTs; and the barrage of content available across the 40-odd video OTT apps, linear TV, sports, events, etc. With so much going on, the smaller films are considered suitable for viewing only on OTTs. To draw the audience to the theatres, Hindi movies have to be really good, consistently, which is not happening now, they say.

RELASING A FILM in theatres is also an expensive affair. The executive quoted above says most films set aside ₹5-10 crore for print and advertising (P&A) costs. Add to it marketing costs, and non-production costs can account for around 25 per cent of a ₹25-30-crore film’s budget. How can a smaller film made on a ₹5-10-crore budget even compete, the stakeholders ask. “Whereas OTTs pay you an assured amount; there are no marketing expenses for the producer. That’s why OTTs are saying, go to the theatres first,” says Jaisingh of UFO Moviez. OTTs are now insisting on a theatrical release of a movie before picking up its digital rights. Hindi films such as *Gehraaiyaan*, *Freddy*, *Cuttputlli*, etc., that went straight to OTTs in 2022 even after theatres had reopened, were mostly pandemic commitments, industry insiders say. “We encourage our producers to take their film to the theatres first, and then to OTTs.